SPARKY'S SCIENCE FACTS

What Are the Different Shapes?

Mathematics · Ages 5+

> **Short answer:** Flat shapes have sides and corners. Solid shapes, like a box or a ball, have faces too.

How it works

- A triangle has 3 straight sides and 3 corners. A square has 4 equal sides and 4 square corners.
- A rectangle has 4 sides and 4 square corners, with opposite sides the same length.
- A pentagon has 5 sides and a hexagon has 6. A circle has no corners at all.
- Solid shapes: a cube (like a dice) has 6 square faces, a sphere is a ball, and a cylinder is like a tin of beans.
- The three corners, or angles, of any triangle always add up to 180 degrees.

Key words: Angle: the turn at a corner; Face: a flat side of a solid shape

Common mix-ups

- A square is also a rectangle: it is a special rectangle with all four sides equal.
- Turning a square on its corner does not make it a diamond: it is still a square.

Did you know? Ndebele house paintings in South Africa are famous for their bold, bright triangles, squares and stripes.

Try it: Go on a shape hunt at home: find 3 circles, 3 rectangles and 1 triangle. Bees build hexagons!

Ask Sparky: How many sides does an octagon have? Why are wheels round?